

MY CONNECTION TO ORAKZAI IDENTITY

BIRTH → FAMILY → PLACE → MEMORY → IDENTITY → FUTURE

My connection to Orakzai begins with where I was born.

My name is Muhammad Faisal Orakzai, and I was born on 30 April 2006 in Mamozai, District Orakzai, Tirah, Khyber Pakhtunkhwa, Pakistan. For me, Orakzai is therefore not an identity I discovered later in life. It was part of my story from the beginning.

I was born into a family connected to this land, its people, and its history. My father, Dawlat Sher, is part of the family story through which I inherited not only a name, but also a connection to the community from which my family came.

The meaning of identity became clearer to me as I grew older. A person's identity can be written on a document in a single word, but living with that identity is much more complicated. It is found in family relationships, in memories, in the places people remember, and in the stories told by parents and elders. And sometimes, it is found in the distance between where a person was born and where life eventually takes them.

FROM ORAKZAI TO KOHAT

My early years were connected with Orakzai and the wider tribal environment. Like many families affected by instability in the region, my family experienced movement and change. We eventually relocated toward Kohat. That transition introduced me to a different environment. The mountains and rural surroundings of my early childhood were gradually replaced by a more urban and educational setting. But moving away from a place does not necessarily mean leaving its identity behind. The connection remained through family, memory, language, and the name I carried.

THE NAME I CARRY

“Orakzai” became part of my identity long before I understood its historical meaning. As I became more interested in history, technology, and the world beyond my immediate surroundings, I began to think more deeply about what the name represented. It was not simply a surname. It connected me to generations I had never met, to a geographical homeland, and to a community whose history extends far beyond the life of any individual. That realization changed the way I looked at my own identity.

IDENTITY AND CHANGE

My life eventually moved into different worlds. Education introduced me to new ideas; business introduced me to markets and people from different backgrounds; technology introduced me to a global community. Blockchain, artificial intelligence, software engineering, and digital infrastructure opened doors that had nothing to do with the mountains where my story began.

Yet I never saw these worlds as opposites. I do not believe that embracing modern technology requires abandoning cultural identity. A person can build for the future while remembering the past, work in technology while remaining connected to their heritage, and live in a modern city while carrying the memory of a place far away. For me, these are not contradictions. They are part of the same journey.

WHAT ORAKZAI MEANS TO ME

I do not claim that my personal experience represents every Orakzai. Every family has its own history, every generation experiences identity differently, and every person carries a different relationship with their homeland. My connection is simply my own. For me, being Orakzai means remembering where my story began while remaining open to where that story can go. It means respecting the people who came before me, learning rather than assuming, preserving culture without turning it into a barrier against progress, and believing that the next generation can carry the identity forward in new ways.

FROM ROOTS TO FUTURE

Perhaps this is the reason I wanted to write this book. There are many stories about people, but fewer stories written by people trying to understand their own connection to those stories. “I’m Orakzai” is my attempt to explore that connection. The purpose is not to romanticize the past or to claim that one person’s story represents an entire tribe. It is to document a journey of identity — from birthplace and family to education, technology, entrepreneurship, and the wider world. The distance between these worlds may be enormous, but identity can cross that distance.

“I’m Orakzai.”

AUTHOR'S REFLECTION

I carry the name Orakzai into every new environment I enter. It reminds me that progress does not require forgetting. The future does not have to replace the past. It can be built on it. My roots are part of my story. But they are not the limit of my story. They are where it begins.